



DELHI | The Heat is On

Summer seems to have arrived early for the Maoists. Feeling the heat of unrelenting pressure from the security forces, they have begun to send several signals that they are ready to talk. Yet unwilling to sit directly across the table with the Government, they have suggested names of activists like writer Arundhati Roy, singer-turned-Trinamool MP Kabir Suman and retired Madhya Pradesh bureaucrat B.D. Sharma as mediators. After a near-farcical exchange of numbers between Maoist leader Koteswar Rao alias Kishenji and the Home Ministry, this is the Maoists' first serious move towards a dialogue. Home Minister P. Chidambaram's appeals to civil society did have some effect—while Suman has agreed to mediate, Roy turned down the Maoists' offer, saying that they should abstain from violence and asked the Government to declare a ceasefire. The Centre wants the Maoists to talk directly and unconditionally. The arrest of senior Maoist leader Venkateshwar Reddy alias Telugu Deepak has the cadres in disarray. Deepak is the biggest catch since Kobad Ghandy's arrest by the Delhi Police last year. Believed to be the mastermind of the attack on the Silda police camp which killed 24, Deepak was arrested by the West Bengal Police after a tip-off. Meanwhile, Kishenji's bluster is intact as he has threatened the Government with more attacks unless Deepak is released. *by Bhavna-Vij Aurora*

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years is what the Home Ministry believes it will take to completely quell the Maoists, who seem shaken by the arrest of Silda attack mastermind Deepak.